finally passed in 2014 and amended in 2015. Myanmar has a history of student activism, beginning in the 1920s with student union opposition to a proposed law on Rangoon University (as it was then known). Since the coup in 1962, the education system, including universities, has come under strict government control. During the recent debate over the new National Education Law, a large range of concerns was expressed, not the least of which was that there had been insufficient consultation in the drafting process. This has been further exacerbated by the limits of the new labour laws, which do not allow student unions to be registered under the new laws.

An area where law reform has arisen directly from violence is in relation to the anti-Muslim sentiment and conflict since 2012. One response was a proposal by a group of nationalist monks to introduce four bills that allegedly seek to 'protect' race and religion, that is, to protect Burmans and Buddhists to the exclusion of non-Burmans and non-Buddhists. These four laws were adopted in revised form by parliament and include the Monogamy Law; the Population Control Law; the Buddhist Women's Special Marriage Law; and the Religious Conversion Law.[29] Yet some aspects of these bills have antecedents in existing laws, linked to previous debates and long-held prejudices against Muslims. For example, the Buddhist Women's Special Marriage Law revises an existing law passed in 1954 (though confusingly it does not seem to replace it, see Crouch 2016). What these laws may potentially do is further entrench discrimination and the marginalization of certain groups, particularly Muslims. Combined, these laws are an overt example of the way law engenders and exacerbates conflict, although much will depend on whether the administration enforces them, or whether certain social groups such as monks pressure enforcement agencies to act in certain circumstances.

TEXTUAL PATTERNS IN LAW REFORM

Across these three areas — structural, economic and social – several patterns have emerged in the drafting of law and the way laws have been designed to avoid and manage conflict, while also at times exacerbating conflict between different institutions or between individuals and the state. I will focus on four aspects: the formation of committees close to the executive to avoid conflict; the wide discretion given to government